intelligence. As far as is known, during the Cold War US intelligence (or indeed any Western intelligence services) never penetrated the Kremlin or had other reliable sources to provide insight into Soviet decision-making (as Ultra had done inside wartime Nazi Germany). What is known is that the CIA did not discover the secrets of the Kremlin in 1962. Neither did the KGB nor the GRU discover the secrets of the White House.

It might also be added that Kennedy's no-invasion pledge amounted to a face-saving formula for Khrushchev. If Khrushchev's principal goal was, as he told the Presidium, to defend Cuba, then it could be claimed (as it was by Khrushchev) that he succeeded. According to this reading, if Kennedy built a golden bridge for Khrushchev, then it lay in front of, and not behind him. In other words, how we see Kennedy's golden bridge is informed by how we see the origins of the crisis and its outcomes.

Dumb luck

There is one overriding lesson that should be learned from the Cuban missile crisis. There is a story that when considering whether to appoint General Michel Ney to become a Marshal of the French Empire, Napoleon Bonaparte is purported to have asked whether Ney was lucky. He might have asked a different question, such as whether Ney understood that if he sent his cavalry to attack infantry formations, he also needed to send guns and infantry to support them. If Napoleon had asked that question, the Battle of Waterloo might have turned out differently. Napoleon's concern with luck is nevertheless of great fascination. What is of greater importance is the relationship between luck and judgement. This may well have occurred to Napoleon as he was fleeing the battlefield after his final defeat. The relationship between luck and skill is equally important – as the South African golfer Gary Player once observed: 'The more I practice the luckier I get.'

Dean Acheson was one of the most influential Western officials in the onset of the Cold War. An author of the policy of containment and an architect of NATO, Acheson was also held responsible by Republican critics for 'losing China' to the communists. He was not a man given to